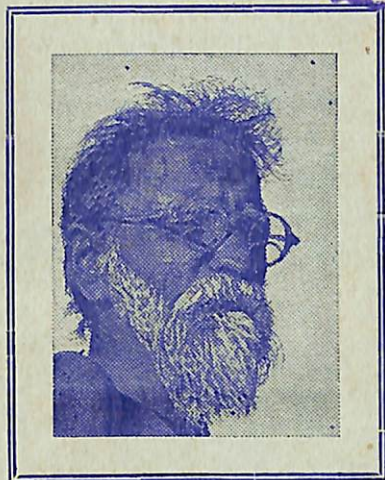
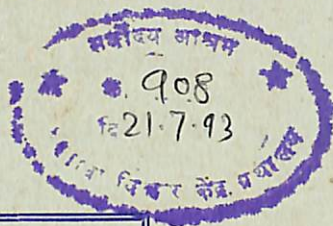


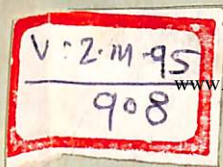
THE VOICE OF VINOBA



Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, Tanjore
(Akhila Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh)

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The Bhoodan Yagna which had its origin on the 18th April 1951 in Telangana has taken now a new turn in the recent months after Vinobaji's entry in Orissa where more than eight hundred villages have offered themselves as Purna-dan (Gift of whole village). This takes the movement to the phase of a real and silent revolution in values leading to voluntary sharing of all land and wealth and dedication of all faculties of individuals towards a new way of life and Sarvodaya Social Order.

The recent speeches of Acharya Vinoba in the Koraput district of Orissa and in Andhra are of great importance. The reader will find a clear exposition in Vinobaji's own words of the basic philosophy and the objectives of the decentralised village Swaraj through the surrender of the individual's land and sharing it with all according to needs. Vinobaji's speeches in the south will appear in this series as "THE VOICE OF VINOBA". We hope that this will help to carry the message of Sarvodaya among the English reading people in India and outside.

Tanjore, } **Sarvodaya Prachuralaya**
 I—12—55 } (Akhila Bharath Sarva Seva Sangh)
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संदर्भ विभाग



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THE SIGNIFICANCE OF GRAM-DAN

IT has been my experience that wherever we go the people give land. The people's devotion and faith has been stirred and they see their own good in Bhoodan. But we find the educated people carry on discussions regarding the success or otherwise of the movement. If it proved a complete success even then they will go on arguing still. There will be no end to their discussions. Those who will think it worthwhile then to join issue with them will be called fools. But if these men of learning only took the trouble to go with us for a few days at least, and see with their own eyes, what the mass-mind, the heart of the common people, is like and how it is being lifted, it will do them immense good.

Some people are opposing Bhoodan without any warrant. After all there are both greedy and miserly people everywhere in the world. But when they organise themselves into parties they get menacingly strong. In India, organisation of political parties make the members close their minds to other's views. Political parties are formed in the West also but this defect never creeps in there.

They have got the experience, running over many years, of political work behind them. Therefore they are more advanced in this respect. But here when a political party is formed, along with it, is created a sort of caste feeling also. I doubt if the members of the different political parties will not hesitate to have their food in the houses of the members of the rival parties.

So when such are the people who are ranged against us, I do not feel it necessary to give any importance to their opposition. When they will see that the movement is gaining momentum in spite of them, they will cool down of their own accord.

Three years ago when we were sojourning in Bihar Sri Jayaprakashji was recouping his health in a Sanatorium at Poona. I wrote to him: 'there are two very strong parties in Bihar; one is the liberal party and the other that of the misers.' In even what is called the Congress party both the liberals and the misers have entered; similar in the case of the other political parties also. I do not recognize the people by their party labels, I do not take into account the existence of parties at all. My approach is directly to the hearts of the people and I consider men as men only. Therefore I gain the support of good people found in each and every party, and am sure that the example of the liberal-minded people in due course will melt the hearts of the misers also. Therefore I never take the trouble of opposing the evil, the darkness as such. I simply go about with the lamp of enlightenment, of truth. Where light enters, darkness clears out.

My words are finding a congenial soil in the minds of the people of (Koraput) district and they are realising the truth of my words. This is proved by the fact that we have received here more than 200 villages as whole-village gifts. This is indeed a great land-mark in the history of the Bhoodan movement since the whole-village gifts movement has its source here. This is the

last lap in its march. The first step was taken with a view to see that there were no landless people anywhere and this is the last step and it aims at removing all individual ownership over land. The owner, the master of all property, is God, and we are only his servants. God has bestowed upon us lands and many other kinds of wealth and He has given them for the good of all. If we claim proprietary right over them to the exclusion of all others, it means that we are usurping the place of God. So we should shed our proprietorship and become servants. Everyone should get and has a right to whatever is required to satisfy one's hunger. But none can lay claim to any right of ownership. This is the last and final step of Bhoodan Yagna. I clearly see that this whole-village gift affair is ultimately going to prove highly revolutionary.

We are everyday receiving village after village *en-bloc*. So the citizens have also a duty in this regard. Because you are citizens you should realise that there is a great movement going on in your district and when your brothers with very little means are sacrificing what all they have, it is the duty of you, well-placed people, to stand shoulder to shoulder with them and contribute your share. Sacrifice is not a bitter pill; it is really very sweet. He who has tasted it knows what it is. I have tasted it to the full and I want to declare here that I have not known sorrow in my life. It is often said that the world is a wale of tears and I have also heard about it. But were I asked what the nature of the world is, I would say that God has filled the world with immense happiness for the enjoyment of his children.

Ananda or happiness is the attribute of the soul. God has not created any being devoid of happiness. No father desires for his children a life of sorrow and suffering. To say that the all-merciful Father of us all, the Great Lord and God has filled the world with sorrow and suffering for us, his children, is nothing but heresy. I do not want to argue the point further and would close by placing my own experience before you: In this life I have not known what sorrow is.

The secret of it is to serve all and wish well to all; in return you will be taken care of and served by all. To-day crores upon crores of people look only to their own interests. They think that only by their being vigilant, will their interests be served. But the poet Tulasidas has testified quite to the contrary and his verdict I have found, in my experience completely confirmed. He has said: "Nothing in this world is impossible for him who has enshrined the good of others in his heart; he gets everything". In this connection a small thing is worth remembering. That is, even if we give away to the maximum, we will give only with our hands. Even if we give our all, what will that amount to, after all having as we do, only two hands to give with? It may not amount to much. But when we receive in return from the society it will be enormous, being the gift from many lakhs of hands. He who gives with his two hands receives in return from hands innumerable. But he who refuses to give even with one hand, cuts that one hand with the other.

More than 200 people of Koraput have given up their ownership over land. When I redistributed the lands in

a village, there a man who had owned 24 acres before, got only $3\frac{1}{2}$ acres at the time of redistribution. He accepted the gift-deed of this $3\frac{1}{2}$ acres in all love. A landless man of the same village got 5 acres, because there was a larger number of members in his family. It is not a story of Satyayuga that I am relating but one that happened in this Kaliyuga. Yugas or ages are the creation of our own minds. As we would make them, they would be made. Even in this so-called Kaliyuga a great soul like Gandhiji was born and even in Thretha Yuga a Rakshasa of the type of Ravana took birth. So it is not the yuga or age that makes us. It is we that create the yuga. A friend was asking me as to the appropriate work that can be done in this Kaliyuga. I told him that he was calling this Kaliyuga after referring to the books, but I have read in the Sastras that people of the Kali Age will be devotees of God-Srimannarayana. I quoted for his information the relevant passage from the Bhagavath of Jagannathadas in which it is said that people in other ages want to take birth in the Kali-Age because it is only in the Kali-Age that one has the real chance to be a Bhakta. Therefore this is not an age of sin, but an age of devotion to Narayana. For my part I consider myself blessed because it was given me to be born in this age.

I have had occasion in the course of my life to come in contact with hundreds of noble souls. India has given birth to innumerable good souls in this age. It is not only they whose names are known throughout the world that are great people. Great people, great souls are lying hidden like gems in each and every village.

Innumerable are the precious stones that are lying unknown, unrecognised, underneath the earth. Only a few of them have been brought out and they are spreading their lustre all round. I believe that those who have given up their rights over lands and are satisfied with the little they are given in the course of redistribution are very great souls. It is the mission of singing their praise that is making me wander about.

When sacrifices are being made in each and every village in this district it becomes the duty of you, the citizens, also to extend your co-operation. No greater fortune can befall our lot than an occasion to do sacrifice. Poets have sung the glory of human life because it is only in it that one gets opportunities for sacrificing. You are getting an occasion to do sacrifice in Sampathidan. I want that everyone should contribute $\frac{1}{8}$ th of his property or income throughout his life. Just as condiments make the food tasty, sacrifices make life enjoyable. There can be no better condiment than sacrifice.

In Sampathidan we do not collect money from the people. It is my desire that there should be opened a bank for this purpose in every household. The donor will spend his gift according to our directions. I want that not only the people of the cities but also those of the villages should contribute a part of their harvest for the good of the villages. When now lands are being redistributed in the villages people of the cities can donate seeds, bulls, and wells for the benefit of the villagers. The face of India will completely be changed

if every citizen, every son of the land, takes a vow to give away part of his possessions for the benefit of people outside his family circle.

Because we are receiving whole-village gifts in Koraput district we have to do four things in the villages concerned: (1) Those villagers who get lands under redistribution should also be given help in order to make them proceed with the cultivation of lands they have newly got. (2) In order to supplement agriculture, village industries will have to be started.

I lay great stress on the village industries. Not many days ago the Governor of Bombay, Sri Harkrishna Methtab suggested that we should concentrate much more on the village industries. He should know that from 1916 to 1948 for a period of 36 years * Baba attended to nothing but village industries. It was only after the passing away of Gandhiji that Baba began to roam about. Had Gandhiji been alive to-day, only he would have been going about and Baba would have continued in the same old work of his. So I fully realise the importance of the village industries and the suggestion of Mehtabji is acceptable to me cent per cent. I have not undertaken this new programme in order to undo what I had done for 36 years previously. I have worked a great deal, have exerted myself to the utmost and have realised to my utter discomfiture that the village industries will not flourish in the absence of land redistribution. Now we are receiving village after

* Vinoba is affectionately called as Baba, meaning father

village in entirety. The people of those villages will, of course, pledge themselves to start the various industries. I have said more than once that I never take the name of Ram or Sita singly but always repeat the combined name of Sitaram. We can call the Bhoodan Yagna and village industries by the respective names of Sita and Rama. You can call either of these by the name of Ram or Sita as you desire. But I am inclined to give to Bhoodan Yagna the name of Sita and to the village industries that of Rama. You know that Sita was discovered under the plough in the earth. Sita and Rama in combination form one complete idea. In the same way the redistribution of land and the village industries when combined, form a complete ideal, the ideal of Sarvodaya.

(3) We will have to make arrangements for education in every village. Our education will be based on village industries, spiritually-centred and more practical. We will have to take Ramayana, Bhagavatha, Gita and other religious books to our villages through education. We will have to train villagers, in the various industries so that they would become experts in them. We want to spread real basic education and not its caricature now in vogue. (4) We will have to organise health services in the villages. Even after we had done all this we will have other things also to do. But these four items are the most important.

Paradoxically enough after the attainment of Swaraj the people have become more dependent. They think that everything will be done by the Government. This

is a very wrong notion. Nothing could be more dangerous. The Government is like a bucket and the people are like a well. The bucket can take only a small quantity of water from the well. Similarly the Government has in its possession only a small part of the capacity which is the people's sole possession. But nowadays a wrong idea that the bucket holds more water than the well has gained way. I have often said that the power of the Government is similar to that of a zero and the power of the people is like that of the digit '1'. The digit '1' and the zero when joined together give the figure ten. Thus when the power of the people and that of the Government are joined together a great power is developed. But when we value either of them separately the people will be found to have only the value of the digit '1' and the Government that of the zero only.

When the people are kept at a distance under democracy what will that Government be worth? The Government is formed by the servants whom you yourself choose. People would be made to feel that they have appointed their servants for carrying on their work. But whatever work is being done should be done according to their ideas and directions. Nowadays in the name of the Welfare State the servants formulate the plans. But the plans should be drawn by the masters and the servants are there only to carry them out. The people of every village should use their brains and draw out plans for their respective villages. Suppose some one falls ill in your village, will you send a telegram to the Minister for Health? Plans for rural health should be

drawn in the village itself. Then the Government should be asked to help in its execution.

It is a basic idea of Sarvodaya that most of the work should be done by the people themselves. Where it is found difficult to carry out the work solely with the manpower of the people the help of the Government can be taken to a limited extent. Nowadays in the name of the Welfare State all education is left in the hands of the Government with the result that where the Government is of the Fascist persuasion children are taught only Fascism and where the Communists have sway Communist doctrines are being taught. Every child in America is taught to look upon the atom and hydrogen bombs as their *Sudarsana Chakra* and to pray "Oh, Bhagavan, you are having the *Sudarsana Chakra* in one hand and the mace in the other and so long as both these unfailing weapons are in your hands, what have we to fear?". The children of America are taught to believe that they have nothing to fear, because their Government has nuclear weapons in its possession. Every child is being daily indoctrinated and injected with this wrong notion of their invincibility. On the strength of this, the powers that be, make their position secure. Therefore we say that education should be free from Governmental control and its direction and control should rest in the hands of the people. The Government can help it but the formulation and direction of policy should never be allowed to pass into its hands.

Just as it is now agreed that the judiciary should be separate from the executive, that the Government should

have no control over the dispensation of justice, the management of education should be in the hands of the people. If I were to make use of ancient terms I would say that education should be in the hands of Brahmins and Kshatriyas should have no authority over it. We had this in our country in olden times. When I say this, I am not having the caste distinctions in my mind. I do not recognise the differences of the castes at all. I believe only in the *Varnas*. That is why I said that I am speaking in the old-world language. According to ancient usage the Government is called Kshatriya and the Brahmins constituted the educational department. In those days no King would dare enter an Ashram and ask the teachers there to give a particular kind of education. If a king entered the precincts of an Ashram it was only for the sake of acquiring knowledge; he had absolutely no authority over the Ashrams otherwise. There is a story relating to the king, Dushyantha. He was a very popular king. In those days the kings used to hunt deers because their number had increased so much that they had become a menace to the food crops. So the kings thought it their duty to hunt them. Dushyantha while thus hunting, happened to enter the Ashram of the sage Kanva. No sooner had he bent his bow for killing a deer than a small boy of the Ashram accosted him thus, "Oh, king, this deer belongs to the Ashram; you dare not kill it." Such is the culture of India, which made even a small boy face a powerful king boldly and prevent him from doing what he intended. We want to revive this culture and that is why we say that education should be in the hands of the people.

To the extent that power changes hands from the Government to the people, Ahimsa will grow and the power of the Government getting slowly diminished will ultimately disappear. That is why I am now engaged in this. Some people say that what we are now doing can easily be done by the Government. I tell them, "Whoever prevents you from doing this through the Government? Do it by all means but I would ask you a simple question: what have you done during the last 8 years? How much land have you distributed? Why, I have heard in certain places that where the Government distributed lands they have gone in auction. I am not mentioning this with a view to criticise; I know, as a matter of fact, the Government itself is gradually veering round towards our view. But I want at the same time to state that there are some things which are impossible of being done by Governments. They can expropriate the lands with the aid of law and distribute them. But it will result only in the breaking of the hearts of land-owners, in creating ill-feeling among them and never in gaining their support. The glory and greatness of Sri Krishna was that he captured the hearts, he stole the hearts of the people. The Government might be capable of capturing anything, but never the hearts of the people. That is why we call the work of Bhoodan and the ideal of Sarvodaya a special ideal. I have already said that you will of course take the help of the Government; and if the Government refused or was unwilling to help it would only have proved its want of imagination.

We want to take the help of the zero, and at the same time want it to keep it in its place. Where the strength

of the people and the Government combine and co-operate with each other, great power results. So you better not tell us that the Government can very well do this work. If you go on in this strain you will come to-morrow and say that your children can be taken care of, and their needs attended to by the Government. The people nowadays have become so weak and helpless that they want the help of law in each and everything. If they want to fix the age of marriage, if they want to bestow love on their untouchable brethren they ask the Government to enact laws to enable them to do so. The people are thus finding themselves helpless in everything and say that the Government is capable of doing anything and everything. That is why I said that after we have attained Swaraj we have become dependent. When the English people were ruling here there was an earth-quake in Bihar; then all the people of India ran to the aid of stricken Bihar. Likewise, when there were floods in Gujerat people from all parts of the land hastened to help. Then in order to save its face the Government had to come forward and help. But what do we see now, when we are enjoying freedom? During these very winter months last year I happened to be going about in Bihar through places devastated by heavy floods. The floods were terrible and unprecedented. I got the opportunity of wading through the worst affected areas. I saw in the town of Sitamadi which looked like an island surrounded as it was by the floods in all directions people visiting cinema houses in the nights unconcerned. Upon this I could not contain myself and asked the people in one of my speeches, whether they had not even the ordinary decency to refrain from spending

on the cinema for a few days at least and contributing the savings towards the aid of the flood-stricken people. But they were thinking that it was no responsibility of theirs, but only that of the Government to help the people of the villages who were the victims of the floods. It is this sort of mentality that I call by the name of dependence or slavery. Do not think we were dependent, when the Englishmen ruled over us and we have now become independent because our own people are ruling.

That country is independent whose every citizen, every child knows his duty, knows his responsibility and does his duty without any fear or favour. That country is free, each and every child of which declares that I am the monarch of my land. What after all is the Government? It is we who have put it in authority for five years. If the Government serves us satisfactorily we will choose it for another term; otherwise we will go in for some other set of servants. You should never think that just as the Moghuls, the Mahratas and the Englishmen ruled over us before, the Congressmen have come to rule now. I want to create in you the power to feel that this Government is your own. That is why I want that the lands and other kinds of wealth should be redistributed through the people themselves. I want this to be done in this manner because I hope that people will thereby come to feel their own strength. The power of the soul cannot be measured. When a great soul gets embodied, descends on the earth it influences the whole world. The soul feels, "While all creation is lifeless I am life, I am the on-looker, the witness and it is I that gives it shape and form". Just

as the potter looks upon the clay in his hands as a stuff to which he can give whatever shape he likes, we can also make the world, give it whatever shape we like. What I aim at is to transmit this belief, this faith in the power of the soul and belief in its capacity and strength to all.

I want that the people of each and every village should come together and administer their respective villages. They should re-distribute their lands and decide what to import and what not to import from outside into their villages and act accordingly. Thus should every village be made into a bastion. We have to do all this. A beginning has now been made through the whole-village gifts. Because your district is in the vanguard of this movement, I appeal to the citizens to contribute their share for its success.

*Translation from the Hindi Speech at
Rayigana (Andhra) on 7—8—1955*

BHOODAN TO GRAM-DAN

WHILE speaking at a meeting in a Koraput village, as I instanced the railway booking office for explaining some point I wanted to drive home, a doubt arose in my mind that these people had probably not seen a booking office or a train at all. Upon enquiry it was found that in that assembly of a thousand people barely 13 had ever seen a train. Thus it is clear that even to the most backward parts of the country the message of Bhoodan Yagna has gone and people are very eager to know about it.

You will see that the enthusiasm and eagerness is not a whit less in Andhra. When the movement began four years ago in Telangana I myself was not aware that a new thing is being born. When land was asked for in a small hamlet, a good man stood up and gave his land. That occurrence was the germ of a new thought in my mind. I could not get sleep easily that night. I was lost in deep thought. The Harijans of the village had asked for 80 acres of land which I had conveyed to the people of the village and in response I got 100 acres. That night my mind began to think about the occurrence and I asked myself if it had any significance at all or it was only a miracle. I knew that man does not do anything by his own thought; ideas are being prepared for him which he adopts. I therefore thought that day that the donor of the day was probably only an instrument of the time-spirit for showing that a new idea has already taken shape in the world. I thought it is quite possible that the landless people in every village will put forward the

same demand as those of this village did. If the people are not dumb the same demand can come from each and every village. So I began to think deeply of the creation of the Universe or what is called God's Plan. I thought, there can be nothing in creation that is incomplete, or imperfect. Everything is perfect and complete. When a child is born it feels hunger. At the same moment milk swells up in the mother's breast. God never makes a partial arrangement. If he gives appetite to the child he provides the mother with milk and also with an eagerness to feed the child with it. So I realised that the Great Power that rules over all is now after some new activity.

Then I began to think of another thing. That was whether I had the requisite capacity for undertaking this work. My mind had no difficulty in answering the question. Immediately the reply came, "No, not at all; your capacity is nil". Then I thought within myself, "True, I am devoid of any capacity. But am I devoid also of faith?". "There is no dearth of faith in you. You are full of it" was the reply. At the time in question I had barely 100 acres. Because of some training in Mathematics I began to calculate in my mind the extent of land that might be required for the whole of India. Something in me began immediately to accost me thus: "What, you have begun to calculate. Then you should be a veritable fool. Because the figure you want to arrive at will be huge". All the same being a slave to the habit, I did calculate and arrived at the figure of 5 crore acres.

Then it struck me in a flash that if I was to be frightened at the result of my own calculations and not to understand the meaning of the day's occurrence, I had better give up my faith in Ahimsa and embrace Himsa or become a pessimist. I was not prepared for either and so took the name of Rama and went to sleep. Next morning I went to the next village as programmed and made mention of the Bhoodan. I had gone there only to see the conditions of the Telangana. I was absolutely ignorant of what began to be called later, by the name of Bhoodan. But I was certain even then in my mind that were Ahimsa to survive I should firmly hold to the sign that God had given me that day. If Sree Rama was able to achieve his purpose through the monkeys could not he through me, a man and a man with faith in Ahimsa do that? I have been an ardent devotee of those monkeys also. So if I could completely shed my ego as those monkeys had done, He who achieved great things through them will achieve by using me also.

So in the village that we reached the next morning with great confidence I begged for land as a son would of his father. At that time none knew that I had come for collecting lands. They in their ignorance had come with flower-garlands for offering me a welcome. I told them, "These flowers are very beautiful. But the mother of these flowers, the mother earth is more beautiful still. I have no need for flowers. They belong to God and to Him be they offered. What I require is only the mud, the land. Let me be given that. I am your child; you are my fathers. If you have four children already take me to be your fifth child,

and allot to me $1/5$ of your lands. Those assembled there had least expected that any such request would be made. Therefore my words had the same explosive effect as the Atom Bomb on Hiroshima. I immediately got 25 acres there. So I thought that according to the teaching of Euclid if two dots are made a line can be drawn by joining them. I got one hundred acres at the previous evening's meeting and 25 acres this morning. Thus having got two dots the line for my future course has been drawn.

It is now four years since all this happened. What was 100 acres to start with grew to one thousand acres later and that again swelled into one lakh and at present we have secured about 40 lakhs of acres. Four and a half lakhs of people have given their lands. Assuming that one in an every 100 who had heard us has given land, on a rough calculation, the message of Bhoodan should have reached at least $4\frac{1}{2}$ crores of people. Those who had witnessed the unprecedented scenes in Bihar have thought that the Satyayuga has dawned. At the end of my sojourn there I had the experience of offering explanation and begging to be excused at a meeting in which some people complained to me that they were prepared to offer Bhoodan, they were eagerly awaiting the arrival of our workers, but were disappointed as nobody had so far gone to their village. So if to such an extent the mind of the people has got ready, we can hardly claim any credit for it.

Thus in the course of the last four years, the mind of the people has become fully prepared. I have already expressed my hope that if we only concentrate all our

efforts in this, India's land problem will easily be solved through peaceful means in the next 2 years. Not only this, I have also given expression to the hope that if this great problem of India is thus solved it will automatically help to establish peace throughout the world; this has begun to be realised by the people of the world also. The thinkers of the world are now watching this tiny movement. Many from distant lands have of late begun to come and join our party with a view to see our work. After seeing what we are able to do they are gaining confidence and say, "Babaji, if this movement succeeds here it will help to establish peace in the world. They ask me, "Do you think that we can also conduct similar movements and succeed in our countries, in the countries of Europe?" I reply them that every country has got its own special problems, but because the heart of man is everywhere the same, the method that we are adopting should prove effective everywhere.

You should look at this work with a comprehensive eye. The concept of Sarvodaya is an all-embracing one. Its foundation is Bhoodan-Yagna. Under the Sarvodaya dispensation all are equal, all are brothers. There are no distinctions of high and low. Just as the Vaishnavas consider themselves to be Bhaktas, servants, the follower of Sarvodaya also should consider himself to be a servant and all others as his superiors, and masters. Sarvodaya says, "Let all others be happy; I am content to receive my portion after all the others have got theirs; that all others be first served and I will be satisfied with the crumbs that remain after the others have been satisfied".

The personification of the Sarvodaya ideal is present in our homes in the person of our mothers. Some people suggest that camps should be organised for giving instruction in Sarvodaya and it should be taught in colleges. I say that this should of course be done. But there is already the ground Sarvodaya scheme in force. It is not a gift of Vinoba. It is being taught by every mother to every child in every home. Every mother administers instruction in Sarvodaya to her child along with her milk. The mother serves food to all the members of the family first and then takes food herself. The Sarvodaya idea is present in this act of the mother. When a living example of Sarvodaya, and instructor in Sarvodaya is thus present in every home there should be nothing in it that may be beyond one's understanding.

A friend had written that Baba is bent upon converting all into selfless mendicants. Baba does not subscribe to the view that man by nature is more selfish than selfless. I say that for man to adopt this notion is wrong. Because the good of man consists only in sacrificing his all for the good of the community. He gains in the same measure as he sacrifices for others. Which selfish man's or miser's happiness can compare with that of the mother in her home? If you have any doubt on the point I would suggest to you to approach any mother and ask her why she does not take her food first and then feed her children. If the mothers are to become students of modern economy and tell their children that because they (children) are dependent on them, (mothers) it is necessary that they (mothers) should keep their body well-fed and in proper trim and so they

(mothers) will take milk before they (children) do, what happiness will they (mothers) get thereby? I do not want to dilate upon this point further as there is this living example of selflessness in every home who is teaching us every moment of her life that by sacrifice, giving up, we get happiness. I only say that you have got the secret of joy, the trick that will lead you to happiness in your own homes and you apply the secret, the trick to your villages. You are anxious, you are worried more about your children than about yourself; If you adopt the same attitude towards your village your happiness will get multiplied many fold.

It is very easy to understand this; nothing could be easier. Because, even the most unlettered have understood this. The people of 350 villages in Koraput have given away their whole villages. I venture to claim here and now that I am giving instruction in true self-interest to our society. *The good of every Indian consists only in his giving up his individual ownership of Land.*

You know how the game of foot-ball is played. If when the ball comes to me I were to take hold of it and keep it firmly in my hands, will the progress or pleasure be derived? Only if on the ball's coming to me, I kick it off towards somebody else does the game go on and pleasure is got. Similarly if we keep the money that comes to us in our own hands we will get no happiness. Happiness comes only as a result of our pushing it back to the society. Suppose you get a piece of sweets and because your hands are well-versed in modern economics, they hold it firmly, you will get starved. But its interest gets satisfied only by putting it into the mouth. If out

of selfishness the mouth keeps the sweet to itself, the mouth will bulge out; and will any pleasure of eating be gained? But moved by selflessness the mouth sends it down to the stomach. If the stomach actuated by selfishness decides to keep it to itself, it will get expanded and will have to be operated upon. But the stomach labours upon it, converts it into blood and sends it all through the body.

In the same way only that society is alive which is always and actively thinking of other's good. Just like the hand which got a piece of sweet puts it immediately into the mouth the society whose members transfer the wealth they get to others is alive. On the other hand, the Society whose members hold firmly to the lands and other property is dead. Once a boy came to me weeping and complained of pain in his ear. Being somewhat given to fun I asked him "If your ear is paining, why is it that your eyes are shedding tears?". But the fact is that pain in one's ear affects the eyes also. It is a sign of life. If even on our striking a big peg in one's ear not a drop of tear comes out of the eyes it should be understood that there is no life extant in him, he is dead. Similarly if the neighbours are not affected by the suffering of a household in a village that village society should be considered lifeless.

It is so very simple that all understand it. Some big people are afraid of contacting Baba. Once somebody approached a big Zamindar and said, "You might have known that Baba has come to our place. Should we not go and see him?". The Zamindar replied, "I have the

greatest regard for Baba. I have read his books. But I do not want to meet him at present." On being asked why, he explained, "If I saw him he will ask me for lands and I cannot refuse him." Upon this the other asked, "Why can't you?" You can, of course, refuse if you have no mind to give. Go and hear what he says and then come back. He has no power to compel, he asks only with love. Then the Zamindar said, "That love has great power. He asks with love and what all he says is true. That is why we cannot refuse him". When the news of this conversation reached me I said it is as good as I have got his lands. He has accepted my words and I require nothing more. If all the people of India had heartily accepted what Baba says, he will not require even an acre of land afterwards. Then where is the necessity for me to take the trouble of collecting and distributing lands? If the same idea that is making me wander about takes hold of your heart, it will make you also wander.

Once a Muslim Zamindar met me. I told him, "If you have five brothers I am the sixth and you give me 1/6th of your lands". He replied, "By the grace of God we are five brothers to be sure". I then said, "Because of God's grace I have become your sixth brother, I want my portion, that is 1/6th of your landed property". He was somewhat clever. So he said, "Among us Muslims the sisters are also entitled to a share in the family property". Upon his saying this, I understood that as he has conceded my claim my case has been won and so asked him how many sisters he had. He said he had two. "So you are five brothers and two

sisters, seven in all. I have become the 8th. So I should get 1/8th of your lands" I said. He at once gave me 1/8th of his lands. If I begin narrating similar stories, those will swell into another Mahabharatha. These eyes of mine have been witness to thousands of similar soul-stirring occurrences. 4½ lakhs of people have donated till now. Even the blind people have given. A sister came one night to give her lands. By the time she arrived we had all gone to sleep. She spent the night there and after offering her lands the next morning departed. There are instances of even children successfully pleading with their fathers to give land.

Brothers, all this go only to show that the Great Power that is ruling over the world has decided to achieve something. We are only to become instruments in its hands. Sri Krishna has told Arjuna in the Gita, "These are already dead. You be but an instrument, O, Arjuna". Similarly I say unto you that individual right of property over land is already dead in India; those who come forward now to give lands will be considered liberal. These will become instruments and benign tools in the hands of the Great Power; these will shine like the Sudarsana Chakra in the hands of Bhagavan Vishnu. Had it not been so, why should these Congressmen approach me and offer their co-operation? Do you think that they had ever got a subscription of 4 annas from Baba? It is easier to extract oil out of sand than to take 4 annas from Baba. The fact is what Baba is saying is true. Nobody is able to ignore it. Baba has placed his firm faith in the Power that is ruling over the Universe,

in the power of the soul, in the power of God—call it whatever name you like.

I am sure that the people of Andhra will not lag behind the people of any other province. Here flow the great holy rivers like Krishna and Godavari which bring their waters from distant places. Will they, who are the beneficiaries of such munificence be miserly? No, they cannot become stingy. People of that land which is so fertile and full of green pastures and is being watered by two such living holy rivers, people so full of faith in God can never become misers.

One thing to be remembered is that our work has been started in opposition to none. The old Sanskrit saying goes '*Sarvesham Avirodhena Brahma Karma Samarabhe*'. The great sacrifice is never done to oppose anybody. We have commenced this, our great Yagna and so we are against none. All are sought only to be reconciled through this. We intend to unite the hearts of all. That is why we believe that all political parties should take part in this. All should understand that this work is being done for the good of all.

The Communists said somewhere that Baba's work is being done in the interests of the Capitalists. This was some three years ago. Their stand is different to-day and they are veering towards us. I have been saying from the beginning that we work to do good to the poor and so all are bound to be sympathetic to us. But when I heard this criticism that Baba is the agent of the capitalists it pleased me immensely. But he is such an agent that if he has got the agency of the capitalists in one

hand, in the other he is keeping the agency of the poor. He serves as bridge connecting both. The bridge takes the people on this side of the river to the other side and those on the other side to this side. He will make them both stand on the same plane and himself taking the role of the priest will join them in wholly wedlock, and take his leave. He will ask them to live a life of love and peace. Thus the movement is one that will join hearts.

India is a big country and its strength lies in unity. If we are all one in mind and heart we will get so strong that we will live eternally. But if on the contrary we are at logger-heads, quarrel with each other—our huge population and the vast area of our country it will undo what all we have done. I really think that when I take lands from the rich I am but favouring them as I think also that I am favouring the poor when I given them lands. Even the poor man is attached to his loin-cloth, is full of the sense of possession. So if I ask the poor to give up their attachment to their cottages, the rich will also have to give up their love for their palaces. But if you will firmly hold to your cottages, they too will hold on to their palaces. It should be understood that the rich and the poor are not two distinct classes. Both belong to the same class. Those who are bent upon sticking to their individual possessions, whether they be big or small, belong to the same class.

We say that God has created the land for the benefit of all in the same way as he has created the air, the water and the light of the sun. If I am breathing good air I am not doing you any harm thereby. If you are

enjoying good air I am not thereby harmed either. But it will prove calamitous if as a result of one's enjoyment of good air another has perforce to breathe fouled air or because one gets pure water another is compelled to drink dirty water. Therefore whatever benefits are available in nature, they are for all and we should order our lives accordingly.

*(From a speech at Parvatipuram (Andhra)
on 8-8-1955)*

Decentralised Swaraj or Gram-Raj

POWER or authority is not a gift to be bestowed by anybody ; it should be obtained from within onself. After all, the people of India are not fools ; they are sufficiently intelligent. How nicely were the last general elections held ! People had expected all sorts of dire things to happen, many breakings of heads, but nothing happened. The people of other countries were astonished and could not believe that the Indians, in spite of their being illiterate, could conduct their elections so peacefully and methodically. The reason for this was that we have the experience of ten thousand years behind us. Though unlettered we are experienced and so wise. That was why our elections went off so nicely.

Intelligent as the people of India are, they have fallen because of their long slavery, into the habit of looking up to the Government as children would do to their father and mother, and believe that the Government will take care of them. Therefore now, when the power to rule has come to their hands they should feel that they are really their own masters. Does anybody invest the mother with the authority of motherhood ? She feels it within herself that motherhood has come to her. Has anybody appointed the lion as the ruler of the forest ? He has become the king by himself. Similarly the authority or the power of Swaraj should be felt by the people within themselves. How is this to happen ? Is it by the people of Delhi ruling over each and every village ? No, the people of the villages will rule over

their respective villages. Then they will gain the experience of conducting the administration.

Administration nowadays is not conducted by the king as was done in olden times, but by the people themselves. In olden times he who was ordering the people about, oppressing and dominating over them became the king. If the lion is called the king of the forest, it means that that animal which eats away all the others becomes the king. In Sanskrit the lion or the tiger is called the king of the beasts. As soon as the beasts see their king they begin to tremble from head to foot. Such a rule has no place to-day. It has given place to the rule by service. What is the authority or power that the mother weilds in the home? When the child cries due to hunger the mother gives it milk; this is her authority number one. She sends the child to sleep first and then herself goes to sleep and this is her power number two. When the child falls ill she wakes all through the night and tends it; this is her power number three. When there are not enough provisions in the house for all the members of the family, she feeds the children and others first and if after feeding them all there, remains nothing for her, she simply starves and this is her power number four. Is not the rule that we are now having our own mother country's? We should have it demonstrated in every one of our villages.

Intelligent, wealthy and wise people will assume the role of father and mother and through their services administer the village. Wise fathers always desire that their sons become wiser than themselves. The father is pleased when he sees his son taking greater strides than

himself in life and the preceptor feels satisfaction when his disciple overshadows him by his eminence. The preceptor thinks, "If even after my teaching the world thinks only of me, what is my teachings worth? I wish, I were forgotten and my disciple's name was on the lips of all. Only then will I consider my instruction to have been of any value". So the wise men of the village will work in such a manner that those who have worked under their guidance will prove wiser for their apprenticeship. Then Gram Rajya will be transformed into Rama Rajya.

Swaraj is to rule over one's own country. The absence of foreign domination is Swaraj. When every village rules itself it is known as Grama Rajya. When all the people of the village become wise and there is scarcely any necessity for ruling over them, it is called Rama Rajya. When there is a quarrel in a village and it is taken to an urban court for enquiry that state of affairs is called dependence or slavery. If the quarrel is settled in the village itself it is called Swaraj or independence. That condition is Rama Rajya in which there is no quarrel at all. We should first establish Grama Rajya and then Rama Rajya. We have obtained Swaraj for the country and we should establish Grama Rajya now. For that purpose Bhoodan Yagna is being conducted. I go from village to village and explain to the people wherein their good lies. I say, "You better think of this yourself; take your village to be a Government in itself. Just as you now call Victory to Andhra Rashtra! and Victory to Bharath Matha! you should hail at the top of your voice Victory to our Village!"

When each village gets victory the country as a whole becomes victorious. On every organ of our body functioning, the whole body functions all right. When the eyes of a man lose their vision, even though all the other organs are working well, he is called blind. One is called deaf when one's ears do not hear even though the other organs are working perfectly. In the same way, when all the villages are carrying on their work well, when Swaraj reigns in every village the Swaraj of our country will flourish also. We will have to carry the administrative set up to every one of our villages. All the departments, the various activities that are generally found in a country should find a place in each village. If there is the Ministry of Public Health in the administration of the country there should be one in the village also. There are the Ministry of Industries, the Ministry of Agriculture, the Ministry of Education, the Ministry of law and so on. And we should have all these ministeries in the village also. If there is a Ministry of Foreign Affairs there, we shall have the Inter-village Relationship Ministry in the village.

Under my plan every village will have its own University. It is a matter for consideration whether it is proper to have the villages as so many bits. That is, Education to the age of four, or one bit of education under the present arrangement will be given in the village; if the village children are to get higher education they have now to leave their village and go elsewhere. This is meaningless. I should be able to get all the education that I want to, in my own village. My village is not a bit or part. It is a complete whole. *Purnamatahah*

Purnamitham — “This is full and that is full”. These people say that this is a bit and that is another bit and by joining the two a complete whole can be formed. Under our arrangement there is no necessity for joining the bits to make the whole. We desire that every village should be a full and complete administrative unit, a State by itself with a full complement of the various departments.

If, in this way every tiny village will have its own administration each village will have a number of experts in the art of Government. There will be experienced people in each village. If the administration at Delhi were faced with any difficulty they would think of going to one or two villages to see for themselves how they are being conducted ; because the villages will have enough administrative talents. So each village will have its own University. It is now complained that there are not people experienced in administration in the villages, even in the districts there are none and there will be only two or three able administrators in the whole of Andhra. If you want to carry on the Swaraj Government, how can you get on were the number of capable administrators so few ? So each village should have a number of experts in the art. Such is our pitiable condition now that when Pandit Nehru expressed a desire to avail of leave for a while from Prime Ministership, the whole country was shocked and all people began to ask him, “How can we get on without you at the helm ?” Well, this is no Swaraj at all. That will be true Swaraj in which when Pandit Nehru wants to be relieved of his burden, people will say, “Do as you desire. Because you have worked

untiringly for us for so long, you have earned the right to rest”.

We should arrange everything in this manner. The administrative machinery established in Delhi should be distributed among all the villages. Since we are all devotees of God let us keep His example before our eyes. Had Bhagavan Vishnu kept the whole of His brain in His own abode, Vaikunt, and not endowed His creation with even a bit of it, how will the creation get on? Then if anybody wanted a bit of intelligence he would have to phone up to the head-quarters and ask for a bit of the stuff to be despatched to him. But God has made the excellent arrangement of distributing intelligence to all creatures. He has not kept the intelligence accumulated in one place. That is why it is said that He has gone to sleep in the ocean of milk without worry. Can our Ministers similarly go to sleep? But God is sleeping in such a manner that we are not even aware of His presence there. That is why some of our brothers ever deny His very existence. Because he is so unobtrusive and so full of patience, He goes to sleep and is not worried whether anybody cares for Him or not. That will be true Swaraj in which the rulers at Delhi will go to sleep with nothing to worry them.

The power was in London before and it has now come to Delhi parcelled up. This was of course good but that parcel has got stuck up at Delhi. It should now be sent to all the villages. If we want to educate the people in self-rule we will have to do all this. This

is known as de-centralisation of power. The power that is now concentrated in one place should be spread over all the villages. When in this way the people of the villages will have become experts in administration and when they will not quarrel among themselves, we would have attained a State when the Government itself will become unnecessary and Rama Rajya will come.

We have to do all this and that is why the Bhoodan Yagna has been started. We say to the people of the villages, "You should gird up your loins for reforming your villages. You should give lands to the landless of your villages. How will lands be got? Will you get lands from other villages? No, you will have to give a part of the lands of your own village. Then you will have to start industries. You will have to decide not to purchase cloth from outside and to prepare your own cloth. I believe that those who wear clothing got from outside are wearing no cloth at all; they are really naked. I see that the people who are assembled here are wearing cloth got from outside and so they all appear to me to be naked and shameless. If import of cloth stops and these people are not able to secure their clothing from the bazaar, they will have to shift for themselves with old and torn clothing and when even that would have gone they will have to go naked; because they have not learned the art of making cloth.

All this the Government cannot do by enacting laws. Some people ask me, "Why is it that Baba is put to the necessity of going about for this Bhoodan work? Why does not the Government distribute the lands that it owns?" Were the Government to undertake the

work of giving lands to the people, we will not have Gram Rajya, but only Delhi Rajya. Instead of the rule of London we now have the rule of Delhi. But we want to replace it by the rule of the villages. Just as only by our own eating will our hunger be satisfied and taking food for satisfying one's hunger cannot be done by proxy, for establishing Grama Rajya we ourselves will have to give our lands and others cannot do it.

And just in the same way as people in Delhi think and decide what to import from outside and what to export from here, people of every village will sit together, think and decide the articles that are to be got from outside and the things that can be sent from the village to outside. Now imports are conditioned by the whims and fancies of whosoever comes to power. But this cannot happen in future. The people of the whole village will meet together, discuss and decide. Suppose someone wants *gur* when it is not manufactured in the village, the people will decide to purchase the quantity of *gur* required for the village for a year from outside. They will not purchase it from the market, but only from the retail shop of the village. Thus will the people get their *gur* requirements for a year and from the next year onwards they will cultivate their own sugarcane and manufacture their own *gur*. That will be kept in the village shop for sale and will be purchased by the people.

In this way the whole village will think and decide things with one mind. If there are 500 people residing in a village there will be 1000 hands and feet

and 500 brains but there will be only one mind. In the eleventh chapter of the Gita, there occurs the description of *Viswarupa-darsana*. The Viswarupa-darsana or the Universal Presence of God is said to have thousands of hands, thousands of feet and thousands of ears and eyes, but it is not said that the divine form had hearts and minds also in thousands. The Universal Presence of God can have only one mind. Similarly the whole village will have only one mind though there will be hundreds of brains. By exercising those brains they will arrive at a decision. This is our Sarvodaya Conception.

Now I would like you to tell me whether you will undertake and carry out this Sarvodaya work or you will expect the people at Kurnool or at Delhi to do it for you. It is of course true that if you formulate your own plans both Kurnool and Delhi will extend their helping hands but it is you that will have to prepare the plan for your place. If you go to each and every one of the Andhra villages and explain what Baba says to the people, being Intelligent, the peasants of Andhra will easily grasp what you say. Then you will not be put to the trouble of collecting, as you now are, one acre here and two acres there. The whole population of villages after villages will go to you and say, "We have solved our land problem, we have given lands to those who were landless in our villages and we have given enough lands to those who had not enough." And after carrying out the formalities like preparing the documents and getting the signatures of the donors on them, they will submit all of them in one bunch at your Bhoodan Samithi Office.

I know it will take time to do all this. But the time taken need not be too long. If one year is required for one village, how many years would be required for the whole of India? Some will begin to calculate by the rule of three, the number of years for the 5 lakhs of villages. But nature does not function thus. When the summer sets in you find the mangoes in your village ripening. At the same time the mangoes throughout the length and breadth of the country ripen also. So in the time that Grama Rajya is established in your village it will get established in all the 5 lakhs of villages throughout India. I want to tell the people of Andhra that if they succeed in spreading this message in each and every village they will not have to engage in the miserly plan of collecting one or two lakhs of acres but will talk in crores.

I have placed before you to-day the whole idea in the form of formulæ. The first formula is *centralised Swaraj*; the second is *de-centralised Swaraj*; and the third is the *absence of Raj* or Rama Raj which can also be called no-Raj, the nomenclature to be decided by each according to his choice. You can say that God is not and can also say that He is sleeping in the ocean of milk. But you cannot say that He is engaged in sweating labour. Either He is not or He is there in the role of *Akartha*. It should not be said of Him that He is the actor and is having His sway over far and near. This great philosophical truth or Brahmavidya should get exemplified in actual life in our country.

It is my earnest wish that you all like brothers should join hands and engage in the work before you. Some people ask, "Is not Vinobaji's proposal one of self-

sufficiency and not of mutual co-operation?”. One should be thankful that they concede at least that our plan is not one of dependence on others. But according to them what is required is mutual co-operation. Not that we do not want it. If Baba took milk for his break-fast to-day did he go to a cow and milk it himself? The milk was got ready by the pepole. Baba is rendering whatever service he could, and in return the people look to his comforts and conveniences. Mutual co-operation is of two kinds. One can be called inter-dependence and the other mutual co-operation pure and simple. Inter-dependence is that co-operation which can exist between a blind man and a lame man. The blind man can walk but not see and the lame man can see but not walk. So they co-operate with each other. The lame man sits on the shoulders of the blind man; while the former guides the latter walks. Do you in the same way want to make some members of the society, blind and some others lame so that they can co-operate mutually? Baba also wants mutual co-operation but he wants also that both should have perfect eye-sight and sound legs and should go forward joining hands. While what Baba wants is the mutual co-operation of capable men these people desire the inter-dependence of disabled men.

Baba also wants mutual co-operation. I know that all the things that one requires in life cannot be made in one village. One village will have to co-operate with another and the villagers in their turn will have to seek co-operation from and offer co-operation to the towns. But I do not want the villages to get their rice hulled, flour made and sugar prepared by the

city mills. I want these things to be made in the village itself. But if spectacles, Thermometers, loudspeakers etc. are required in the village they can be brought from the towns. What has happened to-day is that the people of the towns have taken away those occupations which naturally belong to the villages. The raw materials that are produced in the village can be converted into consumer goods in the village itself. But to-day those materials are taken to the towns and are made into consumer goods by machines and the goods that come from foreign countries into the town are not stopped. I want that the industries that belong to the villages should be conducted in the villages themselves and the towns should concentrate on the manufacture of things that are now imported from abroad for stopping them from being imported. If the village industries are allowed to die, not only will it be disastrous to the villages but it will prove equally so to the towns. The unemployed of the villages will then march on the towns; as there is already the invasion of foreign goods on them, the towns will get crushed like a grain caught between two grinding stones. Therefore my plan envisages mutual co-operation between the village and the town, the villagers being engaged in their own industries and the people of the towns manufacturing those goods now imported from other countries. In this way every village will be a complete unit and there will be co-operation between units which are complete in themselves.

(From a speech at Kotipam (Andhra) on 9-8-'55)

THE BASIS OF SARVODAYA PLAN

WE have to learn a lot from the West, particularly about technology and allied science. There is, however, little for us to learn from the West so far in particular as the social science is concerned. There is otherwise quite a voluminous literature on it in the Western languages. But our culture is quite different from its Western counterpart.

Self-restraint is the outstanding feature of our civilization. We see in the *Gita* that he alone is *Sthitha-prajna* (i. e. he who has acquired the placidity and serenity of the mind) who has all his senses under his control. This is not merely a religious dictum. It is upheld equally strong in our political science and philosophy also. It has been laid down explicitly by Kautilya who was not an authority on Religion and Philosophy but on Economics and Political Science. It is through '*Samyam*'— Self-restraint that the society comes into existence. Where the people do not take to it, its lack causes rift in the society.

We are hearing a lot these days about Socialism. Congress asserts that it aims at a socialist pattern of society. Well, to hear these talks is no doubt quite so pleasing. But Socialism would materialise and manifest itself only when every member of the society would be unreservedly self-restrained and scrupulously observes self-imposed inhibition. When the individual

detaches himself from the body-society and considers himself aloof and independent of it, Socialism is an impossibility. Only that individual becomes a true socialist who faithfully believes in the dictum of *Samaj Devo Bhavo* which means: 'May the Society be the diety to be adored and worshipped' and acts accordingly. Socialism would come into being naturally when every individual would believe and willingly agree to surrender and dedicate his entire energy and other possessions to society.

These days we also see much discussions going on for the economic planning of the country. Disputes and differences of opinion and view-points are mostly centred round what is called the Public Sector and Private Sector, over the questions of what amount of importance and priority should be given to each of them and, lastly, what specific fields of operation and national reconstruction works should be reserved for and allotted to them. This is like asking what work shall be done by the fingers, what by the palm and what by the hand!

If the balance tilts towards the Public Sector, the protagonists of the Private Sector get all stung up and there is great stir and flutter in the leftist camps if it is the other way. And then there are parleys for striking some sort of understanding and compromise between the two, by dividing the work and allotting half to each in the beginning. It is later contended that the share of the Private Sector would be diminished from year to year while that of the Public Sector would

be increased so as to claim and cover the whole ultimately. It comes to this: ultimately the share of the individual would be reduced to zero and that of the society would be raised to hundred per cent.

Now, people ask us what would be the form and structure of the Sarvodaya Plan. We say to them that cent per cent work would be allotted to the 'Private' Sector and, likewise, cent per cent work would be entrusted to the 'Public' Sector, the sum-total of both being a hundred. This is the mathematics of Sarvodaya, which is not taught in the University. Just as hundred per cent authority is held by every member of the family, just as there is no sharing or division and distribution of the individual authority of the father, the mother and the son in the family, and just as there is no distinction made between the family on the one hand and any of its individual member on the other, similarly there is no classification and disparity between the society and the individual. This is the guiding principle and basic concept of the Civilization and Culture of India. The individual shall devote and dedicate his entire energy to the service of the society and the latter in return would grant unqualified freedom to every individual and incorporate in its plan full scope for his development. This is our Sarvodaya Plan.

We do not aim at the reconstruction of the society on the basis of the clash and conflicts of interests of anyone whatsoever. We know that there is no conflict between the different notes of the same octave but, on the contrary, it is entirely resting upon the balance and

harmony between them that the rhyme and rhythm of excellent music are produced. There are a number of Letters in the alphabet; as many as 52 in ours. There is no conflict between them. It is from their proper combination (into words having definite and specific meanings of their own) that we get classical books and literature. There is no conflict between the six basic savours. It is only from their proper application and right proportion that palatable and delicious dishes are prepared. Similarly, in the Sarvodaya Plan of things, there would not be any clash or conflicts between the interests of the individuals or groups amongst themselves or between theirs and those of the society. What is needed is the accuracy and dexterity of planning. If the planning is accurate and adroit, society would stand to get the services of every individual.

But, unfortunately, we have adopted the Western brand of sociology, economic theories and political philosophy. Hence, the clash of interests and conflicts are in great abundance, and hence acceptance and application of the concepts and practice of 'Majority' and 'Minority' have become so common and current. It is essentially because of this contradiction that so many castes and classes are so rampant the whole world over. This has gone so far and deep that it is no more possible to do anything by unanimous agreement and common consent.

Let us scrutinise the working of this majority-minority process. If there are four against one, the resolution is passed; if there are three against two, then also it is passed.

It means that there is simply the counting of heads. This does not necessarily mean that there is more of reason and sagacity on the majority side. Sarvodaya refuses to accept the theory and practice of planning on this faulty concept of 'Majority' and 'Minority'. And, what do we actually see to-day? The whole structure of elections stands, in fact, on these false premises of majority and minority! The decisions in the Parliament also are taken by counting the hands raised in the 'ayes' and the 'nays'. This is the sorry aftermath of the social and political sciences imported by us from the West. The entire emphasis of thinking in this scheme is laid on bringing pressure on the society instead of rendering service to it. The whole approach is based on rights instead of on duties. In the family, no considerations are ever made about the rights of the individual, but only about the duties and responsibilities of the individuals. This is the characteristic Indian way of thought. The Western mode of thinking is based on and guided by the conflicts of interests in the first place. These days we also hear of the conflict of the interests of the teacher and the taught. Even Unions of students are formed to safeguard their interests against those of their teachers. An instance in point is the "All-India Students' Federation". What is left undone or untouched so far is: "All-India Sons' Federation"! It is in this way that our society is being broken up into sections and factions. It has already slipped away from our minds that the whole society is but one family.

In the ancient days, there were only caste distinctions. Class distinctions, dissensions and disputes of the

present day constitute the new ubiquitous crop. There were in those days no clashes as such in the duties and responsibilities of, say, the potter, the cobbler or tanner, the village oil-man, etc. etc. The planning was such that there was no scope whatsoever for any competition. With the passage of time there crept in, however, the false concept and belief of 'high' and 'low', and because of it, all the evils of casteism have shown their ugly face, with the result that factions and sections are ever on the increase.

The scheme and planning of the Sarvodaya Society is of a different category altogether. Ours is one and solitary *Bharatiya Dharma*—or Duty of the Indians. In the Sarvodaya way and style, we wish to render Service to the world. We do not intend either to rob or exploit the world for our own ends, nor are we prepared to be robbed and exploited by anyone in the world. Our efforts would be directed to ensure full freedom to others and to maintain and preserve ours also at the same time. Freedom and Independence of one cannot be in conflict or be opposed to the same of the other. Such a society would more over be based on duty and its pillar-stone would be self-restraint and self-imposed inhibition. Every individual member of the society would always be enthusiastic, willing and prepared to dedicate his services to the society.

Bhoodan has become so popular because it teaches detachment, non-possession, relinquishment and

not attachment, possession or hoarding and epicurean or sensual pleasures. Through this process, we wish that individual ownership or his sole proprietary rights over land should cease; and we want to perpetuate in its place his voluntary service to the soil.

Since when land began to pass into the hands of those who did not and do not till it with their own hands, there has sprung up yet another class of the owner and the tenant, and also the consequent clash and conflict of their interests. We want to put an end to this conflict by conceding the tiller of the soil his due rights and by giving him his due place in the society. He does not desire or demand a 'Lunch Packet' to be served to him, but only of land to render his humble services up to and produce there from, by his own sweat and labour, the basic ingredients of the grub for himself and his kith and kin. We cannot stop him from doing that. On the contrary, it is the duty of the society to fulfil his demand—a demand which he has a right to make.

*(From the speech in Hindi at Pithapuram,
(Andhra) on 8-11-55)*

ALL-INDIA BHOODAN RECEIVED AND DISTRIBUTED

Province	Figures upto	Collection		Distribution	
		Acres	No. of Donors	Acres	Families
Bihar	31-8-55	23,59,879	2,95,790	34,809	19,062
Uttar Pradesh	"	5,53,640	20,940	65,658	31,190
Rajasthan	"	3,59,226	74,803	14,514	2,292
Utkal	20-8-55	2,09,681	81,813	13,210	1,732
Madhya Pradesh	31-8-55	1,16,617	24,638	37,082	6,418
Hyderabad	"	1,09,529	4,286	33,674	7,379
Madhya Bharat	30-6-55	51,987	5,014	311	..
Tamil Nad	31-8-55	42,073	10,751	585	221
Sourashtra	30-6-55	41,000	15,000	1,500	..
Gujarat	31-8-55	39,240	8,877	6,400	2,351
Maharashtra	"	28,146	6,193	..	..
Kerala	30-6-55	25,113	1,200	315	..
Andhra	26-7-55	22,372	..	..	..
Punjab—Pepsu	31-8-55	14,386	3,297	653	161
Bengal	31-7-55	10,596	5,641	1,363	1,158
Delhi	30-6-55	9,245	249	90	25
Mysore	10-9-55	7,796	3,005	..	..
Vindhya Pradesh	31-8-55	6,883	1,470	771	278
Karnatak	"	3,122	620	269	85
Himachal Pradesh	30-6-55	2,025	66	..	..
Assam	"	1,950	..	..	..
Bombay	"	123	6	..	..
Total		40,14,629	5,63,659	2,11,204	72,352

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TRUE DEMOCRACY THROUGH PANCHAYATS

“No law could stop a Panchayat from functioning wherever the people wanted it. Every village (or group thereof) could have a Panchayat system whether the rest of India had it or not. True right came as a result of duty done. No one could snatch away such rights. The Panchayat was there to serve the people. In the true democracy of India, the unit was the village. Even if one village wanted Panchayat Raj, which was called republic in English, no one could stop it. True democracy could not be worked by twenty men sitting at the centre. It had to be worked from below by the people of every village.”

—Mahatma Gandhi

Harijan 18-1-'48

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